The Westminster system has an in-built tension between elected politicians and the permanent civil service. Most Indian civil servants would argue that they are implementers of policy and not policymakers. According to a senior diplomat, every prime minister has his or her own ideas and when they ask for advice from civil servants they pick up what they want and ignore what they do not wish to hear. Realistically speaking, the prime minister has strong views on a handful of issues and limits the permanent bureaucracy's input to methods of implementing his/her ideas. On most other issues, proposals originate in the relevant ministry and move up the hierarchy to the PMO for a decision. Most diplomats interviewed by the author stated that issues relating to India's immediate neighbours or critical countries such as the United States, Russia, the United Kingdom, China or major European Union states are often personally considered by the prime minister.

Even the decisions on non-critical issues depend on how much prominence the prime minister is willing to allow to the external affairs minister. Nehru did not appoint a Minister of External Affairs, preferring to maintain total policy control. Subsequent prime ministers have calibrated the level of freedom of their external affairs ministers depending on personality and political circumstances. Normally, if the prime minister gets along well with the external affairs minister or if a matter does not interest the prime minister, the external affairs minister would have the final say. No prime minister would have an external affairs minister in whom he or she does not have implicit trust though sometimes there is an unwillingness on the part of prime ministers to allow decision-making autonomy to ministers, especially in strategic matters.

Jaswant Singh described the relationship between the prime minister and the external affairs ministry with a pithy anecdote. The external affairs ministry and the PMO in Delhi are both housed in the same building, known as South Block. The prime minister's office is connected to the